Writing a Position Paper

The following material explains how to produce a position paper. A template is provided that outlines the major parts of a good position paper. Immediately following the template are examples for identifying the sources used in performing research using APA style citing and referencing.

A position paper presents an arguable opinion about an issue. The goal of a position paper is to convince the audience that your opinion is valid and worth listening to. Ideas that you are considering need to be carefully examined in choosing a topic, developing your argument, and organizing your paper. It is very important to ensure that you are addressing all sides of the issue and presenting it in a manner that is easy for your audience to understand. Your job is to take one side of the argument and persuade your audience that you have well-founded knowledge of the topic being presented. It is important to support your argument with evidence to ensure the validity of your claims, as well as to address the counterclaims to show that you are well informed about both sides.

Issue Criteria

To take a side on a subject, you should first establish the arguability of a topic that interests you. Ask yourself the following questions to ensure that you will be able to present a strong argument:

- Is it a real issue, with genuine controversy and uncertainty?
- Can you distinctly identify two positions?
- Are you personally interested in advocating one of these positions?
- Is the issue narrow enough to be manageable?

Analyzing an Issue and Developing an Argument

Once your topic is selected, you should do some research on the subject matter. While you may already have an opinion on your topic and an idea about which side of the argument you want to take, you need to ensure that your position is well supported. Listing out the pro and con sides of the topic will help you examine your ability to support your counterclaims, along with a list of supporting evidence for both sides. Supporting evidence includes the following:

- Factual Knowledge - Information that is verifiable and agreed upon by almost everyone.
- Statistical Inferences - Interpretation and examples of an accumulation of facts.
- Informed Opinion - Opinion developed through research and/or expertise of the claim.
- Personal Testimony - Personal experience related by a knowledgeable party.

Once you have made your pro and con lists, compare the information side by side. Considering your audience, as well as your own viewpoint, choose the position you will take.

In considering the audience, ask yourself the following questions:

- Who is your audience?
- What do they believe?
- Where do they stand on the issue?
- How are their interests involved?
- What evidence is likely to be effective with them?

In determining your viewpoint, ask yourself the following:

- Is your topic interesting?
- Can you manage the material within the specifications set by the instructor?
- Does your topic assert something specific and propose a plan of action?
- Do you have enough material to support your opinion?

Organization

Your introduction should lead up to a thesis that organizes the rest of your paper. There are three advantages to leading with the thesis:

1. The audience knows where you stand.
2. The thesis is located in the two strongest places, first and last.
3. It is the most common form of academic argument used.

Sample Outline

I. Introduction
    A. Introduce the topic
    B. Provide background on the topic
    C. Assert the thesis (your view of the issue)
II. Counter Argument
    A. Summarize the counterclaims
    B. Provide supporting information for counterclaims
    C. Refute the counterclaims
    D. Give evidence for argument
III. Your Argument
    A. Assert point #1 of your claims
        1. Give your opinion
        2. Provide support
    B. Assert point #2 of your claims
        1. Give your opinion
        2. Provide support
    C. Assert point #3 of your claims
        1. Give your opinion
        2. Provide support

IV. Conclusion
    A. Restate your argument
    B. Provide a plan of action

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Identify Sources (Citing and Referencing)

Citing and referencing can be tricky. The American Psychological Association (APA) writing style is used for writing in the social sciences, and it is the style recommended by Aspen University in cases where this form of writing is appropriate such as in business writing. Otherwise technical writing style may be used.

When you make a statement of fact or you quote material, be sure to identify (cite) the source like this (Author, Year). Then alphabetically list your references at the end of your paper *like this:*

References
Author, A. (Year). Do not capitalize the title: Just capitalize the first word. City, State: Publisher.
Author, B. (Year). How to reference a source from the Internet. [WWW document] URL http://www.etc.com.
When citing and referencing two authors, include both names in the citation like this (Author & Author, Year). If you state that according to Author and Author (Year), the authors' names are divided by the word "and" rather than by the "&." Do you see the difference? With two authors your reference looks like this:
References Author, A., & Author, B. (Year). Notice how the "&" follows a comma that is placed after the first author's name. City, State: Publisher.
Three or more authors may be cited like this (Author, et. al., Year), and referenced like this:
Author, A., Author, B., & Author, C. (Year). Note the placement of periods and commas used in both the citing and the referencing. [WWW document] URL http://www.etc.
If you need further help in citing and referencing, get a copy of the APA's Publication Manual or visit their Web site at **http://www.apa.org/journals/faq.html**.